

23, A Renewed Critique of Byzantium

Although this obviously carries my strong personal emotional coloration, I must roast the Byzantine emperors: they are exactly **birds of a feather** (一丘之貉) with the monarchs of China's **restoration-bureaucratic period** (复辟官僚时期). As a state born amidst the tide of **feudalization** (封建化), Byzantium did not develop a Byzantine-style feudal system [封建制度] until the 11th century during the reign of Alexios I Komnenos (阿莱克修斯·科穆宁一世), translated into Chinese as the Pronoia system (普罗尼亚制). The Pronoia system emerged later than the Iqta system [伊克塔制度], yet the two were exceedingly similar. Through the Pronoia system, the Byzantine emperor granted the usufruct [收益权] of the land to individuals; this right was non-transferable and not permitted to be hereditary, while the land ownership [土地所有权] still belonged to the emperor. Generally speaking, the grantee could enjoy the land's usufruct for life, but the emperor could still utilize despotic power [专制权力] to revoke the grant. Those granted Pronoia did not bear specific military obligations; the emperor could demand their participation in military campaigns, but this lacked institutionalization. This was certainly not because the Byzantine emperors were kind-hearted and protecting their ministers; the Byzantine emperors' calculations were fundamentally no different from those of Chinese monarchs: once the **feudal landlord class** (封建地主阶级) was allowed to broadly shoulder military obligations, then absolutely nothing could prevent them from mutating into **feudal lords** (封建领主). Furthermore, if the grantees were "short-term tenants" rather than "long-term operators," they were highly likely to frantically exploit the land to reap profits before it was revoked, thereby accelerating the depletion of **social efficiency** (社会效率). Consequently, during the precarious era of late Byzantium, people witnessed a profoundly ludicrous situation: the Byzantine emperors would rather trust pagan mercenaries than take even a single step further toward **feudalization** in power relations. **This is indeed a profoundly Chinese-style ideology: rather let everyone lose than let anyone win; rather let outsiders rule than let one's own people gain power** (宁可所有人都输，不能让任何人赢；宁可让外人统治，不能让自己人得势).

That the Byzantine emperors made certain compromises was merely the result of the development of the **feudalization** process, compounded by the intensified internal and external threats of domestic aristocratic rebellions and foreign invaders. We have every reason to believe that if the situation of the Byzantine Empire had genuinely improved during the Komnenian dynasty (科穆宁王朝), those aristocrats granted Pronoia would likely have been purged. After all, the Theme system (军区制) that emerged as early as the reign of the Heraclian dynasty (希拉克略王朝) had already exhibited glaring **feudal characteristics** (封建特征) and had performed monumental meritorious deeds in resisting Islamic expansion. Yet, when the emperors of the Macedonian dynasty (马其顿王朝) deluded themselves into believing the empire had been resurrected, they exhausted every conceivable method to suppress those increasingly feudalized "provincial military warlords" [藩镇武人]. The empire adopted smaller and more flexible military units to launch counterattacks on the borders (*because the Arab Empire was actively disintegrating*), and remuneration for military service reverted to cash payments rather than land grants. Doing so before the emergence of menacing enemies indeed fabricated a scene of thriving prosperity, but the profoundly deep military defensive system originally sculpted by the Theme system was destroyed (*which is precisely what many Southern Song officials urgently advocated constructing during the early Southern Song Dynasty*). Byzantium stubbornly dragged its feet until even later than the Islamic world before

adopting a *quasi-feudal system* (准封建制度) like Pronoia. Considering that it was even less close to a genuine feudal system than the Iqta system regarding the corresponding rights and obligations, its failure was absolutely irreversible.

By the time Michael VIII (米海尔八世) of the Palaiologan dynasty (巴列奥略王朝) recaptured Constantinople (君士坦丁堡) in 1261, he was forced to allow Pronoia to become inheritable; subsequently, Pronoia holders could even transfer their Pronoia to others. After the "baptism" of the Latin Crusaders (拉丁十字军), Byzantium finally presented the image of a Western European feudal state during its absolute final phase before death. But even when driven to such an absolute dead end, the Byzantine emperors still delusionally attempted to violently clutch the final shred of power in this empire that had practically nothing left. They still refused to grant *de facto* land ownership, retained the capacity to confiscate Pronoia utilizing despotic power, and refused to acknowledge the legitimacy of hereditary succession—the inheritance of Pronoia required explicit approval, even if such approval was generally granted. With the state reduced to such a pathetic condition, imperial relatives were still relentlessly chasing the crown and throne propped up by a bureaucratic system [官僚体制] that was dead but refusing to rot [死而不僵]; in reality, aside from power itself, absolutely no other benefits remained there. Such actions—utterly indistinguishable from those of Chinese autocratic monarchs—coupled with their inherent incompetence and obsession with internal infighting, are more than enough to have many Byzantine emperors eternally engraved in human history as clowns. **Whoever refuses *feudalization* will be utterly defeated by those feudalized Barbarians (蛮族)—it is merely a matter of sooner or later.**

What evokes profound sighs is that the demise of Byzantium is perhaps more valuable than the ten centuries of this empire's existence. Because the failure of Byzantium irrefutably proves one point: the success of Western Europe was not due to the Christian faith, the ancient Greco-Roman classical heritage [古典遗产], or any other widely acknowledged characteristics of Western civilization generated prior to the High Middle Ages [封建盛期]—Byzantium identically possessed these exact characteristics. The sole reason modern Europe could emerge is that it embarked upon the correct historical trajectory, enabling its classical heritage to modernize alongside social development and to create new modern elements. **All thoughts, cultures, and social concepts (社会观念)—components that belong to the *superstructure* (上层建筑) in Marxist theory—are indeed absolutely sculpted by the morphology of *social existence* (社会存在).**

23，对于拜占庭的再次批评

虽然显然带有我强烈的个人感情色彩，但是对于拜占庭皇帝我必须吐槽，他们与中国复辟官僚时期的君主完全是一丘之貉。拜占庭作为在封建化浪潮中诞生的国家，直到 11 世纪，阿莱克修斯科穆宁一世统治时期才发展出了一种拜占庭式的封建制度，汉语翻译为普罗尼亚制（Pronoia）。普罗尼亚制度晚于伊克塔制度出现，但是两者却十分相似。拜占庭皇帝通过普罗尼亚制度将土地的收益权授予个人，这种权益不可转让也不允许世袭，同时土地的所有权仍然归于皇帝。一般来说受赐者可以终身享有土地的收益权，但是皇帝仍然可以使用专制权力撤回赏赐。被授予普罗尼亚的人并非承担特定的军事义务，皇帝可以要求他们参加军事行动，但是却不具备制度性。这当然不是拜占庭皇帝心善保护自己的大臣，拜占庭皇帝的考虑从根本上与中国君主没有区别：一旦让封建地主阶级广泛地肩负起军事义务，那么就没有什么能阻止它们向封建领主转化了。而受封者若是“短期租客”而非“长期经营者”，他们很可能会疯狂压榨

土地以在被收回前获利，从而加速了社会效率的枯竭。于是在拜占庭晚期风雨飘摇的时代，人们看到了一种十分可笑的情况，拜占庭皇帝们宁可相信异教的雇佣兵，也不愿意在权力关系中再向着封建化进一步。这的确是一种非常中国式的思想：宁可所有人都输，不能让任何人赢；宁可让外人统治，不能让自己人得势。

拜占庭的皇帝做出一定的妥协，无非是受到封建化进程的发展，内部贵族叛乱和外部侵略者内外威胁加剧的结果。我们完全有理由相信，如果拜占庭帝国的局势在科穆宁王朝时期真的能够好转，那些被赐予普罗尼亚的贵族恐怕会被清算。毕竟早在希拉克略王朝统治时期所出现的军区制（Theme）就已经表现出了明显的封建特征并且在抵抗伊斯兰扩张中立下了汗马功劳。等到马其顿王朝的皇帝自以为帝国已经复兴时，就想尽办法打压那些日益封建化的“藩镇武人”。帝国采取了更小也更灵活的军事单位在边境发起反击（因为阿拉伯帝国正在解体），兵役的酬劳重新转化为用现金支付而不是给予土地。在具有威胁性的敌人出现之前这样做确实营造了一片欣欣向荣的景象，但是原本军区制度塑造的具有纵深的军事防御体系被破坏了（这恰恰是南宋初年许多南宋官员呼吁建设的）。拜占庭硬是拖到比伊斯兰世界还晚才采取了普罗尼亚这样的准封建制度，就相应权力和义务这一点上还不如伊克塔制更接近真正的封建体制，那么失败是无法挽回的。

等到巴列奥略王朝的米海尔八世在 1261 年收复君士坦丁堡之后，他不得不允许普罗尼亚变成可继承的，随后普罗尼亚的拥有者甚至还可以再向其他人转赠普罗尼亚。经过拉丁十字军的“洗礼”，拜占庭终于在临死前的最后一个阶段呈现出一种西欧封建国家的形象。但是即使到了这种山穷水尽的地步，拜占庭皇帝还妄图捏着这个几乎什么也不剩的帝国的最后一点权力，依然不给予事实的土地所有权，可以利用专制权力没收普罗尼亚，并且不承认世袭继承的合理性，普罗尼亚的世袭必须得到批准，哪怕一般都会批准。国家到了这般田地，皇亲国戚仍然在追逐由死而不僵的官僚体制所托举的皇冠和宝座，其实那里除了权力本身以外已经没有任何其他的收益了。像这样与中国专制君主别无二致的作为，在加之其本身的无能和热衷内斗，足以让拜占庭许多皇帝以小丑的形象被镌刻在人类的历史中。谁要是拒绝封建化，谁就会被那些封建化的蛮族彻底击败，无非是早一点或者晚一点的问题。

令人唏嘘的是，拜占庭的灭亡或许比这个帝国十个世纪的存在更有价值。因为拜占庭的失败无可辩驳地证明了一点，即西欧的成功不是因为什么基督教信仰，古希腊罗马文化遗产等等公认的在封建盛期之前产生的西方文明的特征，拜占庭同样存在这些特征。现代欧洲之所以能产生，唯一的原因就是它走上了正确的历史进程，使得古典遗产能够随着社会发展现代化，并且创造出新的近现代因素。所有的思想，文化，社会观念这样在马克思看来属于上层建筑的成分，的确就是由社会存在形态所塑造的。